

Greatness in the Kingdom of God

One of the most exciting passages in the entire Word of God is Mark 11:23-24:

Whosoever shall say unto this mountain, Be thou removed, and be thou cast into the sea; and shall not doubt in his heart, but shall believe... he shall have whatsoever he saith.

What things soever ye desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive them, and ye shall have them.

But then comes Mark 11:25:

And when ye stand praying, forgive, if ye have ought against any...

We are studying prayer, and Jesus put forgiveness right beside mountain-moving prayer. When you stand praying, if you have ought against any, make reconciliation. Get the strife and unforgiveness out. Then come back and move your mountain. Present the desire of your heart before the Father, and He will not be hindered in bringing it to pass.

Sometimes we underestimate spiritual forces such as forgiveness and the fruit of the Spirit because we do not cultivate those fields. We want the external mountains moved: finances, jobs, position, and circumstances. But there are inner mountains too: strife, unforgiveness, hurts, and strongholds erected in our character.

Jesus thought forgiveness was important enough to include it as the third part of His mountain-moving teaching. We often want greatness in the kingdom without paying the price tag that comes with greatness.

Many people want control. But the person who has control in the kingdom of God was not necessarily given that control by God. Control can be seized. Authority can only come from God.

The line between control and authority is often drawn at the place where natural ability ends and supernatural ability is required. When something stands before you that your own energy cannot move, then you discover whether you have merely held control or whether you have authority from God.

Forgiveness qualifies Mark 11:23-24. It is probably one reason many of us do not operate in more mountain-moving power: we do not understand the place forgiveness holds in authority. There is a price tag with forgiveness. It is not easy to employ in a person's life. But it results in greatness in the kingdom of God: authority to stand in His presence and execute great verses like Mark 11:23-24.

Matthew 18 begins:

At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus, saying, Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?

They were asking who commands the most respect, who merits the most authority in the kingdom of God.

If you want to know where Jesus is going, look at the end of the chapter. In Matthew 18:35 He says:

So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.

Notice He said "every one his brother." Notice He said "from your hearts."

They asked who was greatest in the kingdom. Jesus did not say apostle, prophet, teacher, helps, governments, or operator of diversities of tongues. He pointed to the little sheep, the man or woman of God who has the capacity to forgive every brother his trespasses from the heart.

The greatest in the kingdom, Jesus said elsewhere, would be servant of all.

When the mother of the sons of Zebedee came to Jesus, she asked that her two sons sit on His right and left hand in His kingdom. She was looking for the Messiah to restore Israel, overthrow Roman domination, and establish a place of authority for her sons.

The other ten disciples were moved with indignation against the two. In other words, they got into strife. It is hard for me to imagine twelve disciples sitting at the feet of Jesus and still entering into strife, but it makes me feel a little better about myself, because I know I cannot teach like He can.

Jesus pulled them aside and said that among the Gentiles, rulers exercise dominion and authority by force. If someone will not bow, authority forces him to bow. But He said that authority in the kingdom of God is not gained that way.

Whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister.

Whosoever will be chief among you, let him be your servant.

He was not talking only about a ministry office. He was talking about one person being willing to minister to the needs of another. Greatness in the kingdom is achieved through servitude.

God's authority comes through offering the gift in you, empowered by His Word and the Holy Spirit, in absolute service to others. Not for hire. Hirelings do it for hire. Not for filthy lucre. Authority comes from a willing and obedient heart that offers its gift in servitude.

Jesus called a little child and set him in the midst of them:

Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven.

Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.

If greatness in the kingdom commands the most respect from heaven, then I am humble enough to say I want it.

Jesus used a little child to demonstrate greatness, and that made me study the nature of a child. When my oldest son David was little, we were camping in Oregon. People had left Coke bottle caps around the campground. David walked around picking them up and putting them in his mouth until his cheeks bulged like a chipmunk's. His mother had to pry his mouth open and pull them all out.

Little children will eat anything because they do not know better. They trust whoever feeds them. Whatever you give them, if you say it is good, they will take it from your hand.

Jesus was showing that the new birth is much like natural birth. When you were born naturally, you came in with a clean slate, totally dependent on your parents. When you are born again, you come into the kingdom the same way. You are given the Holy Spirit as Teacher, if you will permit Him to teach you.

To humble yourself is to become teachable. God resists the proud and gives grace to the humble. To humble yourself under the mighty hand of God is to become teachable under the true gifts He has placed in the body.

After speaking of humility, Jesus shifted responsibility to the one receiving the little child:

Whoso shall receive one such little child in my name receiveth me.

But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me...

The word "offend" means to place a stumbling block in the path of a little one, hindering his growth in a way he may or may not recover from.

Jesus said it would be better for such a person to have a millstone hanged around his neck and be drowned in the depth of the sea. I have been to Jerusalem and seen millstones. There are many places I would rather be than taking an afternoon swim with a two-ton millstone around my neck.

There are two areas of offense here. One is strife and unforgiveness. If you are mature in the Word and little ones are within earshot, your bitterness can cause them to stumble.

The other is false doctrine. Little ones are gullible. If you stand up and tell them healing is not for everyone, many will repeat it because a teacher gave it to them. If prosperity or healing was ever for one child of God, it is for all, because God is no respecter of persons.

Paul said he was free from the blood of all men because he had not shunned to declare all the counsel of God. If you do not care enough to take the Word and find out what God says, and you put stumbling stones before little ones, God lays that to your account.

Jesus continued:

If thy hand or thy foot offend thee, cut them off, and cast them from thee...

If thine eye offend thee, pluck it out...

We know He was not telling us to mutilate our physical bodies. The body is part of the temple, and we are not to defile it. But He is talking about dealing with things that can hurt as much as losing a member.

It hurts to deal with the flesh. It hurts to correct false doctrine publicly after you have preached it for years. It hurts to deal with strife and unforgiveness. But Jesus is saying it will not hurt as much as the consequences if you refuse.

Take heed that you do not offend even one of these little ones. Everything in you that is offensive must be cut off at any cost.

I remember when the Lord first showed me this. I was meditating and praying, and I slipped into a vision.

I was speeding down a road in an old car. I ran off the road, the car turned over, the passenger door opened, and I fell out. The car rolled down the hill after me and pinned my hand under the door.

I pulled and pulled, but I could not get free. Then the car caught fire. I knew I had only minutes to decide whether to cut my hand off or burn up in the flames.

Somehow I had a rusty pocket knife in my hand. I cut all the way around my wrist to the bone, then jerked upward as hard as I could and snapped the bone. I ran from the wreck holding the end of my arm. The car exploded behind me, and the concussion threw me into the air. Then I came out of the vision.

As I sat there, the Lord spoke to me. He asked how often a person literally loses a member of his body in such a situation. Not very often. Then the Holy Spirit said, "I want you to cross-examine everything in you, not only doctrinally but offensively, in unforgiveness and strife. Cut it off at any cost."

Who is greatest in the kingdom? The person who has the capacity to forgive every brother his trespasses from the heart.

Jesus said:

Take heed that ye despise not one of these little ones...

For the Son of man is come to save that which was lost.

Then He spoke of the man who has a hundred sheep. If one goes astray, he leaves the ninety-nine and goes into the mountains to seek the one. If he finds it, he rejoices more over that sheep than over the ninety-nine that never went astray.

It is not the will of the Father that even one of these little ones perish.

Then Jesus says:

Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee...

The word "moreover" means He is continuing the same line of thought. Because we have often had ourselves on our minds, we have read the next verses as a process for vindicating ourselves against the brother who trespassed against us. But Jesus has been talking about the little sheep that went astray.

If a brother has the capacity to trespass against you, who is the baby? A person may be born again with a new spirit and still have much flesh to deal with. That little one may trespass against you and go astray. Jesus is giving a step-by-step recovery process for the sheep, not a weapon for your vindication.

We have often read it as, "Go get witnesses, then tell the church, and if he does not repay me, I will treat him like a heathen and sue him." But that misses the Father's heart. God had the lost sheep in mind. We had ourselves in mind.

Why would I sue someone? For the same reason a person lies: he believes the temporary remedy created by lying is greater than the final vindication his Father can bring.

If I lied, it would be because I did not trust the Father with the final remedy of the situation. If I sued to defend myself, it would be because I believed my own vindication would be greater than the Father's.

You can do what you want. There is a good, acceptable, and perfect will of God, and all of it can get you to heaven. If you sued someone and asked me to pray, I would pray that you got a lot of money, because you would need it. But I believe my Father. I believe He is a miracle worker.

The more peace He brings, the more power I find in forgiveness.

Later in Matthew 18, Jesus tells of a servant whose lord forgave him an enormous debt, then loosed him from it. That same servant went out and choked another servant over a small debt.

You were forgiven a ten-million-dollar debt when you were a servant to sin. Anything anyone can do to you in this lifetime amounts to twenty dollars compared with that. Wrecking your business, slapping your face, throwing you in prison, it is still twenty dollars in light of what God forgave

you.

Peter asked, "How many times shall I forgive? Seven times?"

Jesus said, in effect, "Try seventy times seven." That is 490 times, and He was not missing the point. The whole kingdom operates on forgiveness.

I was forgiven a ten-million-dollar debt. It will be a cold day in hell before one of your twenty-dollar debts gets me.

Go on fighting for control in the kingdom if you want. There is another way authority comes:

| The greatest among you shall be servant of all.

Even servant to the person who sued you. It gets harder, does it not?

I cannot wait to receive, in this lifetime, an anointing from God strong enough to not only forgive everyone but loose every person from their indebtedness to me. That is an incredible thing to strive for. That is kingdom-of-God living.

You may say, "I am sure not there yet."

Who said you were? But if nobody opens the door to the road, how will you ever get there?

Do not feel condemned. If you were not feeling condemned before you came in, do not start now. You were in need before you sat down, and God loved you then. Now He will love you through the change.